
MAHA and Clavicular Have United Behind a Strange Health Obsession. It's an Incomprehensible Alliance—Until You Realize One Thing.

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MAHA and Clavicular Have United Behind a Strange Health Obsession. It's an Incomprehensible Alliance—Until You Realize One Thing.

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Peptides are a rising favorite of wellness medical spas and longevity clinics, despite being largely unstudied and sold in the U.S. with research-use-only labels. Supposedly, the compounds are a way to sleep better, heal faster, fight aging, combat certain medical conditions, and in general boost health and vitality. In addition to the influencers who are often paid to promote them, peptides have a champion in Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr., who uses them personally. Last week, a Food and Drug Administration panel narrowly voted—with Kennedy's support—to recommend the loosening of regulations around six peptides. This was another remarkable moment for Kennedy's war against mainstream medical science, given that the FDA's own staff scientists, in a report, had urged the panel against such a decision. But for Kennedy's MAHA movement, the ability to explore peptides without having to circumvent our federal regulatory system is a win for individual medical freedom.

It's worth thinking through why peptides are accepted when so many mainstream medical treatments are rejected by Kennedy and his followers. Self-proclaimed MAHA moms advocate for the freedom to let their children's bodies "naturally" fight illnesses that vaccines could have easily prevented. MAHA activists promote raw milk for drinking and beef tallow for cooking. They talk of the importance of exercise and unprocessed food to defeat chronic disease. And yet, they have been injecting themselves with pharmaceuticals they ordered from unregulated warehouses in China. Why?

"Olympic-level mental gymnastics are required to square this circle," said Timothy Caulfield, a professor of law and public health at the University of Alberta. But as Caulfield noted, the wellness movement has undergone a major cultural change in the past half-decade that has made it almost unrecognizable from the movement that birthed MAHA. And if you understand this turn, the experimental peptides start to make more sense. To understand peptide mania, he said, you need to understand that wellness has become profoundly obsessed with masculinity.

Wellness as practiced and performed by Kennedy is certainly curated to project manliness. He follows a [carnivore diet](#), picks up snakes with his bare hands, and pushes videos of himself doing pushups shirtless and in jeans. His FDA is promoting [testosterone therapy](#) for men while cozying up to men's health influencers such as Joe Rogan and Andrew Huberman. These days, wellness products that used to be branded in spiritual and soft, earthy, non-Western ways during [the Goop era](#) are now promoted by men in tight black T-shirts talking about *optimization* and *hard science*.

Peptides, with their biochemical-sounding names, fit perfectly into this masculine version of wellness. But more significantly, the peptide trend literally emerged from a hypermasculine community in the first place: bodybuilder forums. There, users discussed different "stacks," or combinations of peptides, to reduce body fat and achieve muscle growth. After that, peptides

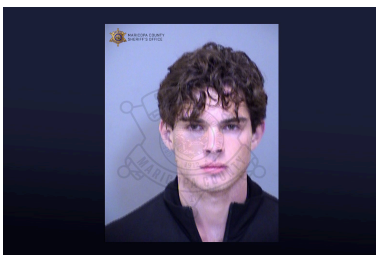
escaped the bodybuilder forums to be discovered by “biohackers”—the Silicon Valley tech workers who are fixated on “optimization” and believe people can hack their way to an ideal state of physical and cognitive performance. They next gained traction with longevity bros, the men who try to use their financial and technological resources to age as slowly and live as long as possible. And they have been promoted to the larger public by conservative male podcasters, Rogan and Huberman chief among them.

If there was any question whether MAHA had lost its natural, body-purity-focused origins, Kennedy’s peptide campaign has answered it definitively: It has. But it also revealed the strange place MAHA has found itself in at this political moment. To survive, they’ve had to connect with groups that have almost incomprehensibly different motivations. And one of these groups is the looksmaxxers.

Looksmaxxing is the internet community in which boys and men, convinced that good looks are the most valuable asset a person can have, share tips to try to become as physically attractive as possible. The most famous looksmaxxer, the 20-year-old influencer known as Clavicular, made a career out of selling destructive ideas about the human body to followers—advising young men to, for example, smash their faces with a hammer to get sharper bone structures. Clavicular has said he started taking testosterone supplements at age 14 and more recently admitted to using crystal meth to suppress his appetite. Others in the community promote risky face-shaping and leg-lengthening surgeries. The looksmaxxing community, in other words, is not too concerned about health.

These teenage boys are also habitually injecting themselves with gray-market peptides. To the looksmaxxers, these peptides aren’t about health; they’re for shedding fat, building muscle, clearing up skin, and even getting tanned. To be clear, the effects of these peptides—strings of amino acids—are medically unknown. It’s unclear if they actually deliver the benefits the looksmaxxers or the MAHA crowd seek, or something else. What we do know is that medical experts warn of extreme risk in their use—there’s some suspicion that at least one of the peptides might accelerate tumor growth.

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But like the current wellness movement, looksmaxxers are preoccupied with masculinity. It's in their DNA: The movement is part of the manosphere, which centers a distinct disdain for women ("foids," in their vernacular) and belief in the sexual conquest of women as a matter of social status. And even more than that, the looksmaxxers unite with MAHA over being at odds with institutional medicine, according to Michael Halpin, a sociologist at Dalhousie University who studies misogynistic internet communities and ideas about health. (Most doctors do not recommend teenage boys inject themselves with growth hormones or get jaw implants.) It may seem like these different factions have extremely different values—those who want to rid themselves of supposedly risky chemicals and those willing to put anything into their bodies to get more defined cheekbones—but there's a shared determination. Neither group wants to be held back by regulations.

"They're different in many ways," said Calvin Mercer, an East Carolina University religious studies professor who writes about human enhancement technologies. "But they're telling the same story. And the story is: 'You don't have to accept the body and the limits you're given. You can outsmart the system.' "

So while peptides are, by origin and by logic, a better fit for looksmaxxers, it's easy to see how MAHA adopted them. As this peptide vote has revealed, it's the shared distrust of the establishment that matters most to Kennedy and his movement at the end of the day.

Maybe peptides will turn out to be just as wonderful as the looksmaxxers and wellness influencers believe. But if peptides end up useless or even harmful, then the main legacy of this particular MAHA wellness campaign will not be a healthier population full of more virile men. It will instead be a greater number of angsty teenage boys, not yet fully capable of understanding consequences, injecting themselves with dangerous, unknown medical compounds in search of more chiseled jaws.

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